THE KEYS COACH

FREE LESSON BOOK

HOW TO IMPROVISE WITH CHORDS

IN 8 STEPS!

THEKEYSCOACH.COM

Introduction

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So many keys players want to just **play.**

They don't want to feel restricted by complex theory and chords.

They just want the music to **flow.**

In this lesson book, I'm going to show you a **game-changing method** for doing just that... being **creative** at the piano and i**mprovising with chords**.

This is a really simple, 8-step formula, and if you follow every step in this book - this really will take your piano playing to the next level.

The **eight steps** are:

Step 1: Choose Your Key

Step 2: Pick a Vibe

Step 3: Build a Bass Line

Step 4: Improvise a Melody

Step 5: Use the 'Claw!'

Step 6: Practise the Triad Shapes

Step 7: Bring the Hands Together

Step 8: Take it to the Next Level...

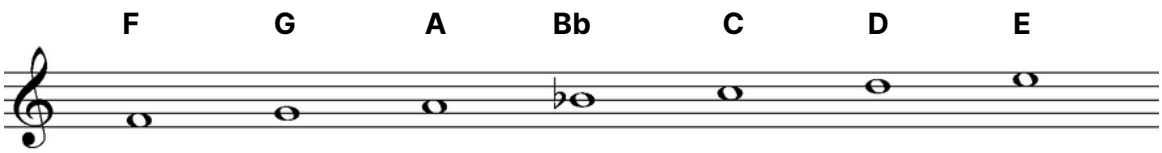
let's go!...

Step 1: Choose Your Key

The first step is to choose a key that is familiar to you. In the lesson video, I choose F - however, you can choose whichever key you like.

Just make sure that particular key is under your fingers, and by that, I mean make sure you have the notes of that major scale really secure in both hands.

Here is the **F major scale**:



Step 2: Pick A Vibe

Now it's time to choose a 'style'. What kind of music do you want to create?

Think about tempo, sound, feel etc.

If you're doing this for the first time, I'd recommend going with something slower, as this will give you a little more 'processing' time when you're improvising.

In the video - I opt for a 'ballad', which is a term for a slow, chilled style.

Really think about what the 'drummer' would be playing, if there was one!

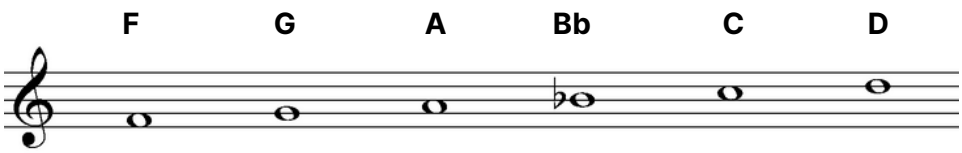
This will help you lock in the groove and develop your sense of subdivision, which is so important in order to sound like your playing has good time and feel.

Step 3: Build a Bass Line

We now need to gather some ideas for what we might play in our left hand. This will act as a 'bed' for our improvisation.

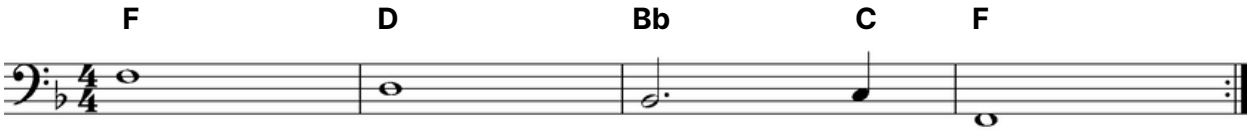
Before we do that - we need to remove a note from the major scale. We're going to remove the seventh degree, which in the key of F major is an **E natural**.

This gives us a **Hexatonic (six note) scale**:



Now come up with a bass line that only uses these notes. It might be a good idea to start on the note F, however, you can go anywhere from there!

Here is the bass line I play in the video:



See if you can vocalise *(or beatbox)* the drum groove, whilst playing this bass line - just like I do in the video.

Even better, see if you can click the pulse with your right hand as well!

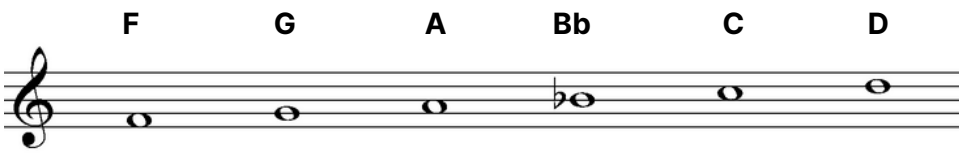
This really helps to develop your hand independence and sense of time.

Step 4: Improvise a Melody

Now try improvising a melody with your right hand.

Keep it simple and don't overthink it - just use the scale and try out various ideas.

To begin with, just the notes in the F Hexatonic scale *(below)*.

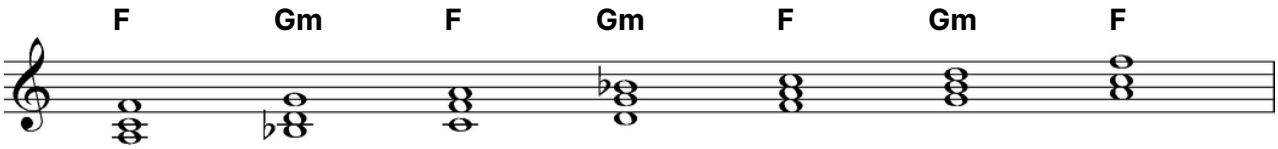


If using all the notes to begin with is a little overwhelming - perhaps start with two or three and build from there.

Try not to start all your melodies from 'F' - try starting them with other notes from the scale. This will help vary your melody line.

Step 5: Use the 'Claw!'

In your right hand play the F Hexatonic scale, but this time you're going to play a **triad** *(three-note chord)* for every note in the scale.



Think of the top note of the chord as the 'melody' note.

These chords are all inversions of F major and G minor.

An inversion is where the notes of a chord are arranged in a different order. For example, rather than **F - A - C**, it could be **A - C - F** or **C - F - A.**

Step 6: Practise the Triad Shapes

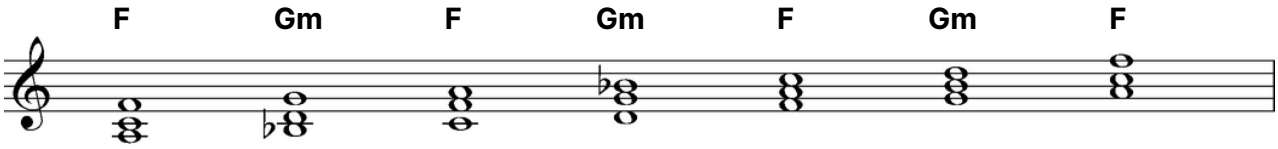
Get these two triad shapes really secure under your fingers.

Try playing a melody again, but this time, rather than a single note - use the 'Claw' technique and harmonise that melody with either an F major or G minor triad.

Step 7: Bring the Hands Together

Now it's time to bring the hands together.

Recap your bass line and then try adding your improvised melody over the top.



Remember your melody can go below the root (F) or above - this will help to make your melody sound even more natural and not 'boxed in'.

Step 8: Take it to the Next Level...

Great work! Now it's time to take it even further!

Try adding an **Eb** into your bass line. While this note isn't strictly in the F Hexatonic scale - it sounds really good and can help take your improvisation to a different 'space'.

If you want to go for a more 'bluesy' sound - try experimenting with an **Ab major triad** (flat 3 in the key) in your right hand (alongside the F major and G minor).

Ab major is based on the flat 3rd in the key of F - so gives it a really bluesy and soulful feel.

Want to go EVEN further? 🚀

Now you're talking!

Try adding an **Eb major triad** (flat 7 in the key). This can really help vary your right hand part and create even more interesting harmonies.

Good luck! Let me know how you get on!

Send me a message, or you could even send me a video of you trying this out! - **adam@thekeyscoach.com**

THE KEYS COACH

Hi! 👋

It's Adam here!

Thanks so much for checking out this lesson book! I hope you find it useful!

If you're interested in more of this type of content, keep an eye on 'The Keys Coach' Instagram and YouTube Channel - there is lots of content coming your way soon!

In the meantime, check out my Podcast! Each week I chat with a different professional keys player about their journey in music.

Whether you're a beginner or a seasoned pro, then this is the podcast for you!

New episodes are released every Thursday!
Available on all streaming platforms.

Cheers!

Adam

The Keys Coach PODCAST

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